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What if someone were to give you a magic wand and say, “Wave this wand three times over any computer in the world and it will magically turn into the PC you have at home.” Well, no such wand exists. But if you are really in need, there is a substitute—in the form of PC-controlling programs and services.

The aim of a PC controlling suite or service is to allow a person sitting at one machine (the local machine) to access another machine somewhere else (the remote machine). Once connected, the mouse and keyboard of the local machine can be used to control the desktop, applications, services and configuration of the remote machine.

Imagine how useful this can be if you want a technician to solve your computer problems without having to pay you a visit, or if you're abroad and need to access files lying in your PC at home or at the office.

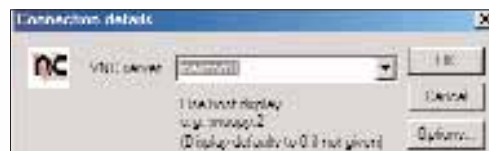
Virtual Network Computing (VNC)

AT&T's VNC is one of the most popular PC-controlling software around, and that is not necessarily because it's free. It is completely platform-independent, so while the local machine runs on Windows, the remote machine can have a different architecture, say Unix. VNC is available under the GNU Public License,

which means the program as well as its source code are obtainable for free.

The software is extremely easy to install and use. There are two components in the package: WinVNC is the software that has to be set up on the remote machine and VNCviewer is the software that is used on the local machine.

VNC's performance is excellent. It runs quite smoothly even from a dial-up connection and makes it extremely easy to make and break connections. So you can start a task, terminate the connection, and then come back later to check if the task is complete.



Use the VNCviewer to connect to the remote machine

VNC is quite good for accessing a machine over a LAN, but you can also use it to access machines over the Internet. To do this, you would have to know the unique static IP address of the machine you wish to access. Good points apart, VNC is not perfect. It does not have the facility to directly transfer files between the remote machine and the local machine.

Two Web-based applications, GoToMyPC and VNC, let you control your PC from any other computer that is linked to the Net

Control kar, yaar!



Photographs: Rahul Sharma Imaging: Ram

Setting up WinVNC

Step 1: Download the package from www.uk.research.att.com/vnc/download.html. Run the Setup program to install WinVNC on the remote machine. When you run WinVNC for the first time, you will be asked to set a password. The program will then run as an application in the system tray. The machine is now ready to accept connections.

Step 2: Copy the VNCviewer program on to the local machine and run it as an application. You will be prompted for the host name. If you are not on the LAN, you will have to enter the unique IP address of that machine. Click OK, and you will be prompted for the password you set.

Voila! A window opens, showing the contents of the remote machine. The remote machine will now respond to the local machine's mouse and keyboard.